

THE INCOHERENCE

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Logline In 12th-century Córdoba, a philosopher-judge confronts a wave of apparent miracles that threaten to dissolve law, medicine, and reason itself; when he uncovers that the signs are engineered by the state to manage belief, he must decide whether clarity is worth exile, disgrace, and the loss of everything he loves.

Screenplay This document is formatted as a readable, production-facing screenplay draft in L^AT_EX. Scene headings follow standard conventions. Action is written for the camera and sound to carry philosophical meaning without explanatory weight.

FADE IN:

1. EXT. CÓRDOBA — COURTYARD OF A MEDICAL SCHOOL — DAY

Midday light cuts hard edges into white stone. The air is hot, dry, and exact. In the courtyard, a low table stands under a thin shade cloth. A brass basin of water reflects a slice of sky with clinical indifference.

IBN RUSHD (AVERROES), early 60s, ink-stained fingertips, physician's composure, sits with a patient. His posture is precise, not gentle. His attention is gentleness.

A STUDENT circle forms: Muslim, Jewish, Christian, a few too young to shave, some older with tradesman hands. In the periphery, a hooded figure in a student djellaba watches closely. This is AÏSHA BINT RUSHD, disguised, stillness practiced.

Averroes takes the patient's wrist. The sound of pulse is not literal, but we hear his internal count as a faint rhythmic emphasis, more felt than heard. He releases. He looks at the basin, at the light, at the patient's breath.

AVERROES

(to the students)

Do not ask first what God intends. Ask what the body
is doing. Intention is not a substitute for observation.

A student, eager, leans forward.

STUDENT

Master, is it not arrogant to speak as if the body obeys
rules?

Averroes does not react with irritation. He reacts with the patience of someone who has seen
this question injure people.

AVERROES

Arrogance is to pretend one sees without looking. The
body is a text. If you refuse to read it, you will call
your ignorance piety and your negligence humility.

He lifts a small knife, not threatening, merely a tool, and opens a swollen abscess with a
practiced incision. The patient flinches, then exhales. Dark fluid drains. The courtyard holds
its breath, then resumes.

Aisha watches the procedure with a steadiness that is too mature. She does not watch for
drama. She watches for method.

As the wound is cleaned, the camera finds a clepsydra in a corner: a simple water clock in an
alcove, drip and measure. It is part of the environment, as natural as shadow.

CUT TO:

2. INT. COURT OF LAW — HALL OF JURISTS — DAY

A different chamber, same light. Geometry everywhere: carved arches, repeating patterns.
The room is full, but quiet. The air smells of paper, sweat, and restraint.

Averroes now sits as QADI, Chief Judge. His hands are the same hands. Ink, medicine, law.
On one side, a BUILDER with lime dust in his beard; on the other, a LABORER with an

arm bound and bruised.

A collapsed wall has injured the laborer. Testimony hangs on causality: negligence or misfortune, poor mortar or sudden wind, rushed work or bad stone.

BUILDER

The wall fell because God willed it. Who am I to
argue with the decree?

The phrase lands softly, like a blanket offered to responsibility. A murmur of approval in the audience.

AVERROES

God wills that we act with knowledge. When a wall
falls, it falls by the weight of stone and the weakness
of what binds it. If you build with sand where lime is
required, do you call the collapse a miracle?

A JUNIOR JURIST, sharp-eyed, rises with the careful courage of someone speaking where speech is dangerous.

JUNIOR JURIST

Master, if you say the wall must fall from weakness,
do you not bind the Creator to a chain of necessity?

The room stills. The clepsydra is not present here, but the same rhythm appears as a faint emphasis in the silence.

AVERROES

To say that a thing has a nature is not to deny its
Maker. It is to affirm that creation is not a jest.
If nothing follows from anything, then judgment is
theatre and law is noise.

He turns back to the builder, not cruel, just exact.

AVERROES

Bring the mortar. Bring the stones. We will examine
what you used. If you did not know, you are negligent.
If you knew and did it anyway, you are culpable. God
is not insulted by evidence.

The builder swallows. The laborer exhales. In the audience, a few faces harden: not disagreement yet, but the first sensation of being deprived of a comforting explanation.

CUT TO:

3. EXT. GREAT MOSQUE — ARCADED COURTYARD — LATE AFTERNOON

Crowds spill from shade into light. The sound is layered: footsteps, murmurs, distant recitation, water in channels.

At the center of the marble expanse, a large iron BRAZIER has been prepared. Coals glow. The heat is visible in a slight shimmer.

A CONDEMNED MAN stands before the brazier, wrists bound. Officials read a sentence. The crowd is not bloodthirsty; it is hungry for moral reassurance.

Averroes is present among jurists, not presiding, observing. Aisha is there as well, still disguised.

The condemned man is made to step near the flame, closer than safety permits. A guard pushes him. His tunic is heavy linen, perhaps. Ordinary enough.

The flame catches the hem. We hear the expected whisper of cloth and fire. It begins. Then, abruptly, it does not proceed. The hem blackens a little, then stops. The man cries out, but not in pain. In fear, in shock.

The crowd surges. Some shout praise. Some weep. A preacher, unknown to Averroes, lifts his hands.

PREACHER

Do you see? He burns whom He wills, and preserves
whom He wills. Fire has no law. It has only the
command.

Averroes steps forward, not to interrupt, but to look. He looks at the tunic's drape, at the way it hangs. It is wrong, but only to someone who has handled many textiles.

Aisha looks at faces, not at the brazier. She registers relief, the way a crowd leans into an answer that removes burden.

CUT TO:

4. INT. INFIRMARY — PRIVATE ROOM — NIGHT

Oil lamps. Low light. A calm enclosure. The condemned man lies on a mat, trembling. A guard waits outside.

Averroes examines him as a physician, not a judge. He lifts the tunic carefully. Beneath the line where cloth covered, the skin shows small blisters, not severe, but real, and not consistent with a divine suspension of fire.

AVERROES

(softly)

Tell me what you wore. Tell me what they gave you.

The man avoids his eyes.

CONDEMNED MAN

They said it was a mercy. They said it would not
burn. They said I would live.

Averroes touches the fabric between thumb and forefinger. He feels weight. He listens for rustle. He hears almost nothing.

AVERROES

Who said it.

A knock. Hard. A guard enters without waiting for permission.

GUARD

Enough. The Council requests your presence tomorrow. There is talk in the streets.

Averroes holds the tunic for a moment longer, then lets it fall back. The lamp flame flickers. The room feels smaller.

CUT TO:

5. EXT. CITY SQUARE — DUSK

The light turns amber. Shadows lengthen into corridors. The crowd has gathered around a raised platform.

The ASHARITE PROSECUTOR, late 40s, austere white robe, persuasive calm, stands like a man who has made peace with uncertainty by declaring it holy. He does not look at the crowd to win them. He looks above them, as if speaking upward.

PROSECUTOR

You have been told that the world is a machine of causes. That if you know the parts, you can predict the outcome. But what is that machine, if not a cage built around the Living Will?

Faces lift. The rhetoric does not instruct; it relieves.

PROSECUTOR

If fire burns because it must, then prayer is decoration.
If the sick recover because bark and blade insist, then
mercy is a name we give to necessity. But the Merciful
is not necessity. He is freedom.

A murmur of assent. Not all hostile, but all warmed by the idea that unpredictability is intimacy.

In the back, Averroes watches. He does not show anger. He shows fatigue, the kind born of recognizing a rival method: not falsity, but a competing comfort.

Aisha watches the crowd. She notices how people hold each other more tightly as the

Prosecutor speaks, as if the doctrine itself were a blanket.

CUT TO:

6. INT. LIBRARY — NIGHT

A chamber of shelves, shadowed alcoves, and careful quiet. Aisha enters alone, still disguised. She lights a small lamp.

She opens Aristotle in Arabic translation. She copies with speed and accuracy. Her hand is steady. She pauses at a line where a translator has softened a causal claim into something vaguer, safer.

She hesitates, then corrects the word. The ink is dark, decisive. A tiny act of treason against ambiguity.

A LIBRARIAN appears from the shadows, older, cautious.

LIBRARIAN

Do you know what you risk when you correct a text?

AISHA

I risk being wrong.

LIBRARIAN

No. You risk being precise. Precision attracts attention. Attention attracts men who do not read.

Aisha closes the book gently, as if to protect it from the room itself.

AISHA

If we remove the bones from the argument, it becomes a story. Stories are easy to burn.

The librarian does not answer. He only extinguishes a second lamp in the far corner, making the room darker, safer, and smaller.

CUT TO:

7. EXT. IRRIGATION CHANNEL — MARKET DISTRICT — DAY

A bright morning. Market noise. Baskets, cloth, shouting, bargaining. Water runs in a stone channel beside the stalls, a mundane civic miracle.

Then it begins to flow the wrong way. Not violently, not like fantasy, but enough that anyone watching feels the subtle nausea of contradiction.

Women cry out. Men laugh in disbelief, then stop laughing. The Prosecutor's followers arrive quickly, too quickly. They point. They narrate.

FOLLOWER

Do you see? Habit is a veil. The Lord lifts it when
He wills.

Averroes arrives late, pushed through a crowd. He kneels by the channel. He touches the water. He looks along the stone line as if reading a sentence.

He hears, faintly, the drip of a water clock that is not present. The film supplies the rhythm as a question.

The flow returns to normal before he can trace the full line. The crowd treats the return not as correction but as closure. They have received their sign.

CUT TO:

8. INT. PRIVATE STUDY — DAY

A room inside Averroes' house. Papers piled. A writing board. A small brazier. The clepsydra is present in an alcove, drip and measure. Its sound is calm, but now it reads like a deadline.

Averroes writes. The title line is formed: *Tahāfut al-Tahāfut*. The Incoherence of the Incoherence. His hand is not inspired; it is disciplined.

He pauses, not from doubt, but from awareness of the city pressing in. He dips the pen again. He writes as if building a wall against a tide.

Aisha enters silently with a ceramic jar, careful not to spill. She sets it down. Inside is a

strip of cloth, folded. Ordinary enough.

AÌSHA

This was left near the brazier after the punishment.

No one claimed it.

Averroes does not touch it immediately. He looks at it the way one looks at an insect one suspects carries a fever.

AVERROES

They have begun to manufacture God.

AÌSHA

Or to manufacture the people.

Averroes finally lifts the cloth. It hangs wrong. The sound is too quiet. The clepsydra continues: drip, measure, drip, measure.

AVERROES

If the city can be made to doubt the reliability of fire,
it can be made to doubt anything. It will not be a
city of law. It will be a city of interpretation.

Aisha watches him, not pleading, not arguing yet. She is learning what kind of war this is.

CUT TO:

END OF PART I

FADE OUT.

Screenplay — Part II

FADE IN:

9. INT. AVERROES' STUDY — CONTINUOUS — NIGHT

The same room as before, but later. Lamps burn lower. The clepsydra continues its patient drip.

Averroes writes, pauses, crosses out a sentence, rewrites it with greater austerity. This is not revision for elegance, but for necessity.

Aïsha sits opposite him, copying a passage from Aristotle onto a separate sheet, her handwriting slightly tighter than his.

AÏSHA

You are answering him as if the city were still listening.

AVERROES

I am answering him as if the argument were immortal.

Cities close their ears. Texts do not.

She hesitates, then chooses to speak.

AÏSHA

Do you remember what you told me about Fez?

Averroes looks up. The question catches him not emotionally, but temporally.

AVERROES

Which telling?

AÏSHA

About the woman who built a school because she believed knowledge needed a home sturdier than any ruler.

Averroes leans back. The clepsydra drips.

AVERROES

Fatima al-Fihri. Yes. She founded al-Qarawiyyin with inheritance money. Not for prestige. For continuity. He gestures at the walls, the shelves, the city beyond.

AVERROES

When princes change their minds, buildings remain. When doctrines fracture, institutions carry memory forward.

AÏSHA

And they still teach there. Law. Medicine. Astronomy.

AVERROES

They teach that learning is not a spectacle. It is a discipline that survives rulers by refusing to serve them directly.

Aïsha looks at the manuscript between them.

AÏSHA

Then why not leave? Why stay and argue with men who have already decided they want miracles instead of syllabi?

Averroes does not answer immediately.

AVERROES

Because Córdoba was built to be such a place. If we abandon it without resistance, we concede that the only future for learning is exile.

He returns to the page.

AVERROES

And because arguments written under threat are often
the ones that travel farthest.

CUT TO:

10. INT. JEWISH OPTICIAN'S WORKSHOP — DAY

A narrow room flooded with angled light. Bronze mirrors, glass lenses, astrolabes. Everything is orderly, dangerous, precise.

The OPTICIAN, older, hands stained with polish and resin, adjusts a concave mirror. He treats it with professional intimacy.

Averroes stands nearby, watching the reflection of the window detach and reform as the mirror tilts.

OPTICIAN

This mirror can show you the heavens or make a fool
believe an angel has landed in the square.

AVERROES

The difference being the crowd.

OPTICIAN

The difference being intent.

A flare of light dances briefly on the wall, forming a shape that looks almost purposeful, then dissolves.

OPTICIAN

I have been asked to lend this mirror to the Governor's
men. I said no. They asked again, this time with
smiles.

AVERROES

And you still said no.

OPTICIAN

I said that mirrors do not lie. People do. They did not appreciate the distinction.

Averroes watches the mirror one last time. Its reflections shift subtly, never stable.

AVERROES

In Bologna, they argue about law as if it were geometry.

The Optician raises an eyebrow.

OPTICIAN

Italy?

AVERROES

Yes. A place where jurists gather and call themselves a universitas. A corporation of minds. They believe that argument itself can be an institution.

OPTICIAN

Does it work?

AVERROES

For now.

A pause.

OPTICIAN

Will it work here?

Averroes does not answer. He does not need to.

CUT TO:

11. EXT. ALCAZAR — CALIPH'S PRIVATE GARDEN — NIGHT

Engineered calm. Water channels. Lemon trees. Moonlight filtered through leaves.

The CALIPH stands alone. Averroes approaches. The clepsydra's rhythm returns faintly, now tense.

CALIPH

They say you wish to turn Córdoba into Bologna.

AVERROES

I wish to keep it from becoming a shrine to confusion.

CALIPH

Fez can afford endurance. Bologna can afford debate.
I must afford obedience.

The Caliph turns, weary.

CALIPH

You think institutions preserve truth. I think they
preserve habits. The people no longer trust habits.
They want signs.

AVERROES

Signs decay. Habits build.

CALIPH

Habits also rebel.

Silence. Water moves through channels.

CALIPH

Write if you must. Teach if you can. But understand this: the city will not follow you into a world where God behaves predictably.

AVERROES

Then the city will have to learn elsewhere.

CUT TO:

12. INT. GOVERNOR'S CHANCELLERY — NIGHT

Ledgers. Maps. The concave mirror now wrapped in cloth, catalogued.

The SECRETARY marks a schedule.

SECRETARY

Fez produces scholars. Bologna produces lawyers. Córdoba produces arguments. Arguments are unstable.

He gestures to a timetable.

SECRETARY

Tomorrow, we produce certainty.

CUT TO:

FADE OUT.

Screenplay — Part III

FADE IN:

13. EXT. EASTERN GATE — MORNING

The gate is massive, Roman stone repurposed by centuries. Morning light catches dust in the air. A crowd gathers with anticipatory quiet, not excitement. They have learned how to wait for wonder.

The ASHARITE PROSECUTOR stands among them, not presiding, but witnessing. His expression is composed, yet a hairline fracture has appeared—an attentiveness that borders on suspicion.

A MERCHANT approaches a fountain near the gate. He holds an empty palm aloft.

MERCHANT

By God who provides, I ask for relief from debt.

The merchant dips his hand into the water. When he lifts it, coins glint wetly in his palm.

A gasp ripples outward. Knees bend. Some weep.

The Prosecutor steps closer than he has before. He watches not the coins, but the merchant's eyes, the angle of his wrist, the timing of the crowd's intake of breath.

As the merchant turns away too quickly, the Prosecutor steps forward—and his foot catches on something.

A faint metallic sound: not a ring, but a duller note.

He looks down. Between the stones lies a misshapen lead slug, one face stamped, the other blank, attached to a thin gut-string that vanishes into the fountain's shadow.

The sound of the crowd fades. We hear only the Prosecutor's breathing and, faintly, the drip of water that sounds suddenly like counting.

CUT TO:

14. INT. GOVERNOR'S CHANCELLERY — LATE NIGHT

Maps, ledgers, oil lamps. The room hums with administrative purpose. The SECRETARY packs documents into a chest.

The Prosecutor stands in the doorway, the counterfeit coin clenched in his fist. His robe is disordered, his certainty frayed.

PROSECUTOR

I found this at the gate.

He drops the coin onto a ledger. It lands with a dead sound.

SECRETARY

The world is untidy. Even miracles leave scraps.

PROSECUTOR

Do not mock what you pretend to serve. I saw your men. They were not praying. They were counting.

The Secretary closes the chest calmly.

SECRETARY

You believe you are defending God. I am defending the city. We are not the same profession.

PROSECUTOR

You are making a puppet of the Almighty.

SECRETARY

I am making certainty. The people cannot live in the “perhaps” of philosophers. They need the “is.”

He steps closer, voice low.

SECRETARY

If you tell them the coins were tricks and the water was valves, you will not free them. You will leave them alone with their hunger.

The Prosecutor’s face tightens. His faith is not shattered; it is cornered.

PROSECUTOR

If the miracle is a lie, then what we protect is hollow.

SECRETARY

Then pray harder. Or look away. Both are acceptable.

The Secretary sweeps the coin into a refuse bucket without ceremony.

The Prosecutor leaves. The bucket remains. The ledger remains. The city's theology has been itemized.

CUT TO:

15. INT. AVERROES' STUDY — NIGHT

Stacks of parchment. The brazier glows low. The clepsydra drips more loudly now, as if the room were smaller.

Averroes reads a draft, grimaces, and feeds it into the fire. The paper curls, blackens, vanishes.

Aïsha watches from the doorway, holding a satchel.

AÏSHA

That was persuasive.

AVERROES

That is why it must die.

AÏSHA

Persuasion is how texts survive long enough to be understood.

AVERROES

Persuasion is how tricks survive long enough to become traditions.

Aïsha steps forward and retrieves a half-burned page with tongs, stamping out sparks.

AÌSHA

Then I will carry the drafts you refuse to save. Someone must bridge the distance between clarity and hunger.

Averroes looks at her—really looks—and sees not defiance, but strategy.

AVERROES

You are preparing for exile.

AÌSHA

I am preparing for survival.

CUT TO:

16. EXT. CÓRDOBA STREETS — NIGHT

Averroes walks alone. Shuttered schools. Chained library doors. Smoke carries the chemical tang of ink and skin.

He enters an INFIRMARY courtyard.

INT. INFIRMARY — CONTINUOUS

ZAYNAB, a senior physician, works over a fevered child. A blessed stone rests uselessly on the girl's chest.

ZAYNAB

They tell me touching her pulse interferes with God's test.

AVERROES

And the fever?

ZAYNAB

They say it is a sign. Signs do not respond to willow bark.

She lowers her voice.

ZAYNAB

They asked today whether I taught your daughter her letters.

Averroes stiffens.

ZAYNAB

The city is retreating from explanation. When that happens, it looks for bodies to blame.

She meets his eyes.

ZAYNAB

Leave. Take her north. Fez endures because it does not argue with hunger. Bologna endures because it argues with everything. Córdoba wants miracles.

CUT TO:

17. EXT. GREAT MOSQUE — COURTYARD — DAY

The public disputation. The brazier again. The mineral cloth prepared, folded, plausible.

Averroes stands opposite the Prosecutor. Aisha watches from the edge.

Averroes calls witnesses. Weaver. Dyer. Builder. Procedure replaces rhetoric.

Ordinary linen chars and smokes. The mineral cloth does not. Silence where crackle should be.

PROSECUTOR

You see? Even now He answers arrogance with mercy.

AVERROES

Look closer.

Water poured onto the cloth. No steam through the weave.

AVERROES

It is stone spun into thread. It does not burn because
it has already endured greater heat.

Averroes lifts the cloth from the fire with bare hands. The crowd recoils.

AVERROES

The miracle is a dyer's secret and a politician's coin.

The Prosecutor's face collapses inward.

PROSECUTOR

If this is a trick... then the sign is gone.

AVERROES

The world remains.

No cheer. Only embarrassment. People look away.

CUT TO:

18. EXT. AVERROES' HOUSE — DUSK

Red dye marks the door. Silence where neighbors once greeted.

Inside, Zaynab helps Aisha pack. Efficiency without sentiment.

ZAYNAB

You murdered comfort. They will never forgive you
for that.

Guards appear at the street's end.

CUT TO:

19. EXT. REAR ALLEY — NIGHT

Averroes and Aisha slip away with a single satchel. Firelight rises behind them—ordinary fire, obedient to wind.

CUT TO:

20. EXT. PROVINCIAL TOWN — DAY

Averroes teaches a handful of bored youths. They ask whether philosophy will help them advance.

AVERROES

No.

They leave.

CUT TO:

21. EXT. GUADALQUIVIR RIVER — NIGHT

A barge carries grain, oil, and a manuscript.

DISSOLVE TO:

22. EXT. PYRENEES — DAY

A mule collapses. A trader salvages vellum for padding.

DISSOLVE TO:

23. INT. MONASTERY SCRIPTORIUM — DAY

A monk translates by cold light, hides Arabic under chant.

DISSOLVE TO:

24. INT. UNIVERSITY OF PARIS — DAY

Scholars debate Aristotle in Latin. Pens scratch. Bells toll.

An elderly Aisha watches anonymously.

CLERK

They say the author died cursed.

AISHA

He died early.

CUT TO:

25. EXT. PARIS STREET — CONTINUOUS

A blacksmith strikes iron. Rhythm. Reliability.

The sound carries upward over the city.

FADE OUT.

Screenplay — Part IV (Integration and Coda)

FADE IN:

26. EXT. PROVINCIAL HOUSE — NIGHT

A modest dwelling. No geometry, no marble, no ornament. Wind moves dust across packed earth.

Inside, AVERROES lies on a low bed. His breathing is shallow but measured, as if even now he refuses drama.

AÏSHA sits beside him, older now, her disguise abandoned. The satchel rests against the wall, patched and repaired many times.

AVERROES

Do you hear it?

AÏSHA

The wind?

AVERROES

No. The same thing I heard in Córdoba.

Silence. Then, faintly, a rhythmic sound enters—not literal, but familiar. A hammer striking iron somewhere beyond the house.

AVERROES

Even here.

Aïsha understands. She does not respond.

AVERROES

I wanted the argument to be unassailable. I forgot that arguments do not travel alone.

AÏSHA

They never have. They travel with hunger, trade, fear, and accident. That is not corruption. It is logistics.

Averroes smiles faintly.

AVERROES

You sound like a merchant.

AÏSHA

Fatima al-Fihri used inheritance money to build a school. That was commerce too.

Averroes closes his eyes.

AVERROES

Then promise me this.

AÏSHA

What?

AVERROES

If they argue over my words, let them. If they misunderstand me, let them. But do not let them forget that I believed the world could be known without diminishing God.

AÏSHA

They will not remember that.

AVERROES

Then they will rediscover it.

His breathing slows. Then stops. No music. No emphasis. The wind continues.

CUT TO:

27. EXT. UNIVERSITY OF PARIS — DAWN

Cold light. Stone walls emerging from shadow. Bells ring for morning lecture.

Students move through courtyards carrying books, arguing as they walk. Their breath is visible in the air.

Inside a lecture hall, the REGENT MASTER writes on a slate: *Causa et Effectus*.

REGENT MASTER

If the effect is severed from the cause, the intellect has
no ladder by which to ascend.

Pens scratch. The sound echoes.

AÏSHA, now elderly, stands at the threshold. She does not enter. She listens.

Beside her, on a bench, rests the Arabic manuscript. Its pages are brittle, ink fading, margins
scarred by travel.

She opens it once more, tracing a line with her finger.

AÏSHA

(to herself)

You survived badly. That is how truth survives.

She closes the book and leaves it on the bench.

The camera lingers. A student sits, notices the unfamiliar script, frowns, then returns to his
Latin notes.

CUT TO:

28. EXT. BLACKSMITH'S FORGE — CONTINUOUS

Iron is struck. STRIKE. STRIKE. STRIKE.

Sparks fly. Heat radiates. No miracle. Only work.

The sound carries outward, merging with the murmur of the city, the bells, the scratching of
pens.

FADE OUT.

END

Final Note

This concluding movement closes the loop without resolution-as-vindication. Averroes does not triumph; he persists indirectly. The institutions of learning outlive the city that rejected them, not because they are purer, but because they are adaptable. The film ends not with certainty restored, but with causality resumed as background infrastructure—no longer debated, simply used.